Q+A

SPRING IN HER STEP

Kathak exponent ***Aditi Mangaldas*** *on her first-ever duet* Mehek, *premiering at Grand Theatre, Mumbai, on April 11, and how to dance like you're 16 at 65*

Photograph by ARUN KUMAR



Q. In *Mehek*, you team up with British-Indian artist Aakash Odedra. What took you so long to do a duet?

For me, it's important to be immersed in the piece. Where is the *katha* in it? Where are we going with it? Opportunities came with other forms, but what I seek is the coming together. That kind of intense exploration never happened with anyone.

Q. *Mehek* centres on a relationship between an older woman and a young man. It also defies ageism by proving that you can match steps with a younger man.

I don't think that way at all because it brings too many barriers. If a 40-year-old amazing guy is going to be in love with me on stage, I am going to feel like 16. *Mehek* looks at how timeless love is. When there's a relationship between an older woman and younger man, there are so many sanctions. If it's the other way around, no one bats an eyelid.

Q. You've been on top of your game not just physically but even creatively. How do you sustain the passion and rigour for dance?

My son put it really well, 'Mom, obviously you can't dance like when you were 20.' But what does dance mean? Is it only taking 100 *chakkars*? Physicality, emotionality and intellectual rigour don't have to be on a rollercoaster always. As you grow older, pauses become important. They are where you draw in energy and flower again.

Q. How do you maintain the temple that is your body to ensure it functions with the kind of precision you display?

I realised a long time ago that there are no shortcuts. Weight training, *kathak riyaaz*, yoga and contained breathing all help. At the same time, I don't stress myself. I am also in the company of amazing young dancers who I get energised by. Both the personal and dance family are important. These widening circles of love and care make diving into the ocean of dance all worth it.

—with Suhani Singh